But did the Taliban have control over these training camps given Al Qaeda and the ISI's role in sustaining them? Sahay, India's former spymaster says that in R&AW's assessment, the Taliban did have the capacities to clamp down on these camps.[116] However, it was unwilling to do so given its links with the ISI, and ideological affinities with HuA. MoD analysts, examining Pakistan-Taliban relations in 2000, however, offered a nuanced reading, i.e. these camps were 'not vital to Taliban policy' even if they were central to Pakistan's policy in Kashmir and Afghanistan.[117] The few Afghans who fought in Kashmir in the 1990s cannot be directly linked to the Taliban.[118] If anything, the Taliban had consistently denied their active presence (or any such intention) in Kashmir, even if they had sympathy for Kashmiri separatists. Confidential conversations between US officials at that time confirm that the Taliban had no intention to halt training of HuA cadres, which had begun as part of a deal with the ISI.[119] The Taliban's lack of resistance to HuA's presence on its territory seems like a pragmatic decision that ensured continuous material and diplomatic support from Pakistan.

Secondly, how was New Delhi so clear about not engaging with a 'Pashtun dominated' force? The certainty portrayed around the 'Islamic fundamentalist' argument is counterintuitive given India's historical and cultural engagement with radical Islam. Some antecedents such as the Indian National Congress' support to the Khilafat Movement between 1919 and 1924, and New Delhi's unhindered diplomacy with post-1979 Shiite Iran and the Wahhabi Gulf states are cases in point. Interestingly, India also accepted the presence of the radical Islamist and pro-Pakistan Hekmatyar in the Afghan government in 1992 (even though Hekmatyar never really joined the government in Kabul). Thirdly, given India's active dealings with the UF after 1996, it was clear that New Delhi was not shy of engaging with Afghans regardless of their ideological bent and human rights record. Neither were the UF commanders less Islamic nor did they have clean human and women's rights records. India's foreign and security establishment, effectively, faced a dilemma over who to support in Afghanistan and how. Compounding this dilemma was the fluidity of events on the ground in Afghanistan and India's domestic security and political challenges throughout the 1990s. If in 1992 the conciliators dominated policy formulation, the worsening